

Riccardo Di Cato

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Placement Director: Prashant Bharadwaj

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Education

University of California San Diego

2021–present

Ph.D. in Economics (expected 2027)

Research areas: Development Economics, Political Economy, and Economic History

Advisors: Sara Lowes and Samuel Bazzi (co-chairs); Paul Niehaus, Gaurav Khanna, and Craig McIntosh

University of Bologna

2018

M.Sc. in Economics, LMEC (*summa cum laude*)

University of Pavia

2016

B.A. in Economics

Job Market Paper

Seeds of Market-Based Capitalism: Missionaries, Banks, and China's Modernization *with Jiachen Li*

The adoption of modern financial institutions is central to economic development. As modern banks entered nineteenth-century China, Christian missionaries expanded deep into the interior and brought foreign knowledge and skills. Did missionaries shape where modern banks were adopted? If so, did these early differences contribute to the recent rise of market-based capitalism in China? Before 1936, we use a staggered difference-in-differences design and find that missionary arrival increased the number of modern banks by 31% and enterprises by 27%. Newly compiled data on mission schools, publications, bankers, and elites suggest that practical education and translations facilitated the transition from traditional to modern finance. Modern Chinese banks also benefited from complementarities with traditional banks. We then estimate the long-run effects of missionary exposure after 1949 using variation in the timing of railway construction relative to national missionary inflows. The historical banking advantage lay dormant under Maoist central planning and re-emerged as markets reopened after 1978. Locations with greater historical missionary exposure have higher GDP, more enterprises, and greater foreign investment, indicating broader effects on market development. Overall, the adoption of new organizational forms depends on the complementarity between local human capital and an institutional environment conducive to market development.

Work in Progress

Same Faith, Different Politics: Religious Broadcasting and Voting in Italy and Spain *with Mattia Albertini*

Restricting Online Pornography and Violence Against Women: Evidence from India and the United States *with Santiago Cantillo*

Increasing Female Employment in the Automotive Sector in India *with Garima Sharma, Anant Nyshadham, and Achyuta Adhvaryu*

Religious Broadcasting and Belief Formation in Tanzania *with Mattia Albertini*

Employment

National Bureau of Economic Research	2022
Research Assistant (Prof. Samuel Bazzi)	
Bocconi University	2019–2021
Research Associate (Prof. Nicola Limodio and Prof. Filippo De Marco)	
Harvard University	2018–2019
Field Research Associate in the DRC (Profs. N. Nunn, J. A. Robinson, S. Lowes, and J. Weigel)	
Entrepreneurial Venture	2015–2020
Founded and managed a hospitality business operating three tourist residences in Italy	

Presentations

SIOE Conference, INSEAD	2026
HHDI–NIDE Workshop, Belfast	2026
IRES Workshop, Chapman University	2026
ASREC Conference, Chapman University	2026
ASREC Conference, George Mason University	2025
SOCAL Conference, UCLA	2025
DevPEC Conference, UC Berkeley	2025
University of Bologna WiP Seminar	2025
Migration and Development Conference, Bologna	2024
Boston University Center for the Study of Asia	2024

Teaching Experience

University of California San Diego	2021–present
<i>Graduate:</i> Financial Accounting; Quantitative Methods II; Quantitative Methods III	
<i>Undergraduate:</i> Microeconomics (principles and intermediate); Financial Accounting; The Indian Economy	
Bocconi University	2020
<i>Undergraduate:</i> Financial Markets and Institutions; Public Finance	

Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

Cindy Vojtech Summer Research Prize in Economics, UC San Diego (\$1,667)	2026
IHS Research & Travel Grant (\$2,500)	2026
Summer Research Grant, UC San Diego (\$2,600)	2024–2025
Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics (\$6,885)	2023
21st Century India Center Travel Grant, UC San Diego (\$8,500)	2023
TRELS Grant, UC San Diego (\$1,000)	2022
Overseas Scholarship, Université de Montréal	2018
Erasmus Scholarship, Université Pierre Mendès France	2015

Referee Service

Journal of Development Economics; Economic Development and Cultural Change, Mission Studies

Mentoring and Community Involvement

Co-founder, Undergraduate–Graduate Economic Research Lab, UC San Diego
 Co-founder and co-host, Backstory Podcast at UC San Diego
 Organizer and director, church summer camp, Omegna, Italy; college-student mentor
 Co-founder, “Yes, I Care” community-meeting project; volunteer with Suñu Diwaan, Senegal

Additional Information

<i>Programming</i>	Stata, R, ArcGIS, L ^A T _E X, GeoODK (advanced); Python (intermediate); Matlab (basic)
<i>Languages</i>	<i>Native:</i> Italian. <i>Fluent:</i> English, French. <i>Intermediate:</i> Spanish.
<i>Citizenship</i>	Italian citizen; U.S. permanent resident; married to a Spanish-American citizen